inscription on the Hathigumpha rock cave outside Bhubaneshwar, inscribed in about 150 BCE, where he speaks of a *tamira samghatta* or 'Tamil confederacy', although in its earliest form the word was *dravida*, which much later gave rise to 'Dravidian', the term now used to describe the family group of languages widely, but by no means exclusively, spoken south of the Narmada (see Map 1 on page 11).

We are, in essence, talking about two distinct peoples and cultures. Consider and contrast, for example, the two key states of Uttar Pradesh (UP) in the north and Tamil Nadu (TN) in the south. Both play hugely important roles within their respective regions as social, political and religious hubs but are utterly different in so many ways. The present population of the state of UP (roughly the size of the United Kingdom) is well over two hundred million, which is nearly three times that of TN (roughly the size of England). According to the 2011 National Census the female literacy rate in UP is 59 per cent as compared to TN's 74 per cent; the mortality rate for females between birth and twelve months is 87 per 1000 in UP and 54 per 1000 in TN; the sex ratio is 91 females per 100 males in UP and 100 females per 100 males in TN. In terms of social make-up, one fifth of the population of both states is made up of persons classed as belonging to the Scheduled Castes, also known as Dalits and formerly known as Untouchables, and in both states the so-called Scheduled Tribes, formerly known as Tribals, make up just 1 per cent of the population. However, in other respects the two states are markedly different: Muslims make up 19 per cent of the population in UP and 6 per cent in TN, which also has a 6 per cent Christian population; Brahmins make up 11 per cent of the population in UP but only 4[4] per cent in TN; high-caste Thakurs and Vaishyas make up 10 per cent of the UP population, but in TN this designation breaks down entirely because of the absence of established higher-caste categories. One other statistic which I find significant is that